

STUDENT VOICE

THE AMERICAN LANGUAGE CENTER • FES

alcfezbook.com • facebook.com/ALC.Fes.ALIF

Volume XII, Issue 3 • March 2021

Si David Amster

As one door closes, another opens.

Si David, what an honour to interview you for the *Student Voice* under somewhat bittersweet circumstances. After a 25-year tenure directing and expanding the ALC-Fes/ALIF, you are moving on to different things. Let's go back to the beginning.

Where is "home" for you?

David Amster: Well, that's kind of a difficult question. I grew up in California and Michigan, where my family is, spent my early adult years and went to university in Chicago, but have been living overseas since 1991. I have been here for 25 years and would say Fes is definitely where my heart is.

What has your career trajectory been?

DA: I've always been a teacher at heart. Actually, I started volunteer teaching when I was 12 and at 13, started tutoring math. I studied Classics (Greek and Latin Language and Literature) at the University of Chicago and taught Greek and Latin at a high school for four years. Because of my background in Greek and Latin and love of art, my next job was at an art gallery selling Roman and Greek antiquities. But I learned that the art business was not for me, and I missed teaching, so I went back to university and did a Masters in Applied Linguistics/TESOL.

You spent five years in Egypt before coming to Morocco. Tell us about that.

DA: After I finished my Master's in TESOL, I got a teaching position at the American Language Center in Alexandria, Egypt. So, for three years, I taught

English and American Literature and trained Egyptian English teachers. That's also when I started studying Arabic seriously and discovered how much I loved Islamic architecture. Then I

So why Morocco?

DA: Growing up in Michigan, my best friends were Syrian and Jordanian, so I learned some Arabic when I was a kid and really felt kinship with Arabic-speaking cultures. The first time I visited Morocco was on holiday in 1995. I fell instantly in love with Fes, the history of the medina, the architecture, and craftsmanship. I decided I wanted to move to Morocco, and in September 1996, I began teaching at Al Akhawayn in Ifrane. That fall, I was a guest speaker at the All-ALC conference, and after my presentation on "The Use of Poetry in the Teaching of English," I was approached and offered the directorship at the Fes ALC! So, I finished the semester in Ifrane and moved to Fes in December 1996.

When you started here, what were the big challenges for you?

DA: When I arrived, the ALC was a language school with large class sizes and a low passing grade. I was keen to elevate the language and teaching standards at the Fes ALC, so I embarked on creating a language and cultural center of high quality, where the students profited from smaller

class sizes, excellent teaching, and the teachers benefitted from academic respect and good financial remuneration. I also really wanted to create a sense of cultural exchange, so we launched many cultural and community activities, and over the years we have created our excellent bookstore, acquired the ALIF Riad for cultural activities, and developed many





*“Now the eager mind longs for roaming,
now happy feet become lively with eagerness.” - Catallus*

community service projects, like the English Teacher Internship Initiative (ETII).

I also wanted to renovate and restore the physical structure of the ALC and ALIF, focusing on historical restoration and respecting the craftsmanship traditions of Morocco and Fes, while creating a nice work and study environment for our students and staff. I really wanted to make the ALC a beautiful place to study and, like a garden, nurture cultural exchange, while offering excellent English and Arabic language instruction.

What do you consider your biggest achievement and your biggest challenge over the last 25 years?

DA: One of my favorite projects has been our fantastic bookstore. I'm also very proud of all our cultural activities, concerts and clubs. I've had to gradually

learn how to be less direct and frank when dealing with people, to cushion bad news or constructive criticism more gently.

Cross-cultural communication is always complex, and the subtleties of human resource management were one of my greatest challenges.

What influenced your decision to move on to other things?

DA: I think like many people, the time spent in quarantine was an opportunity for self-reflection and re-assessment. I realized that after 25 years in an administrative role, I had reached a threshold and achieved what I had set out to do. (Nothing's perfect, of course!). I also realized that I needed to feed my soul again, with learning and teaching, continued study and travel. I miss the academic and intellectual pursuits of language and literature and I realized that

it's time for new things.

After 25 years, how does it feel to hand over the ALC-Fes/ALIF to the new director, Christian Sinclair?

DA: I'm absolutely delighted that the ACA Board worked so hard to identify and hire a person as qualified and experienced as Mr. Sinclair. I am certain that the ALC and ALIF are in very good hands, and that Christian will be able to take the Center on to new heights. I wish him all the best in Fes and at the ALC and ALIF.

Si David, it's been an honor and a pleasure interviewing you, and we are very grateful for your time. Your presence at the ALC will be greatly missed. On behalf of all the staff at the ALC/ALIF, we wish for you a joyful and blessed continued journey.

Extramural Pursuits

Si David is known as the director of the ALC, but he is also known for his restoration efforts throughout the Fes medina, in both public and private spaces.

David has been particularly enamoured with the living cultural heritage of the Fes medina from the first day of his arrival. Aside from the restoration and development of the ALC buildings, he made it a personal mission to renovate and restore four houses, a Quranic Madrasa and many public medina fountains. He has also assisted others in the authentic restoration of their private houses, making certain that the craftsmen's traditions, ancient materials and methods were honoured.

As his friend Lori Wood describes: "I first met David when he came here 25 years ago, shortly after I arrived as an ALIF student. Over the years, his faithful restoration of multiple properties and

projects throughout the medina, has helped to raise the standard for both private and public restorations. He treated the artisans' work as a precious treasure, the work of the generations of artisans before who built the Fes medina."

I asked David where he thinks this devotion comes from.

DA: Well, I grew up very poor. My father was a professional archer, so there was never any money. My grand-mother was an artist, so I learned to love painting

from her, and I used to go with my mother to flea markets and antique markets. She always had a \$1 budget, so we would buy things, restore them together, and furnish our house this way. I still have some of those pieces to this day. I also started collecting old things as soon as I got my first job and had money to spare. I love old things and the stories they tell.



Photo: riadzany@blogspot.com



Photo: D. Amster.



Photo: ALIF Riad Exhibition - ALC. Photo Club

David's Favorite Poem

*I'm Nobody! Who are you?
Are you – Nobody – too?
Then there's a pair of us!
Don't tell! they'd banish us – you know!
How dreary – to be – Somebody!
How public – like a Frog –
To tell your name – the livelong June –
To an admiring Bog!*

Emily Dickinson (1830-1886)

WHO AM I?

I love good food but cannot cook.
My middle name is Wayne.
I graduated from high school in 1976.
I love poetry and Classical literature.
My favourite color is green.

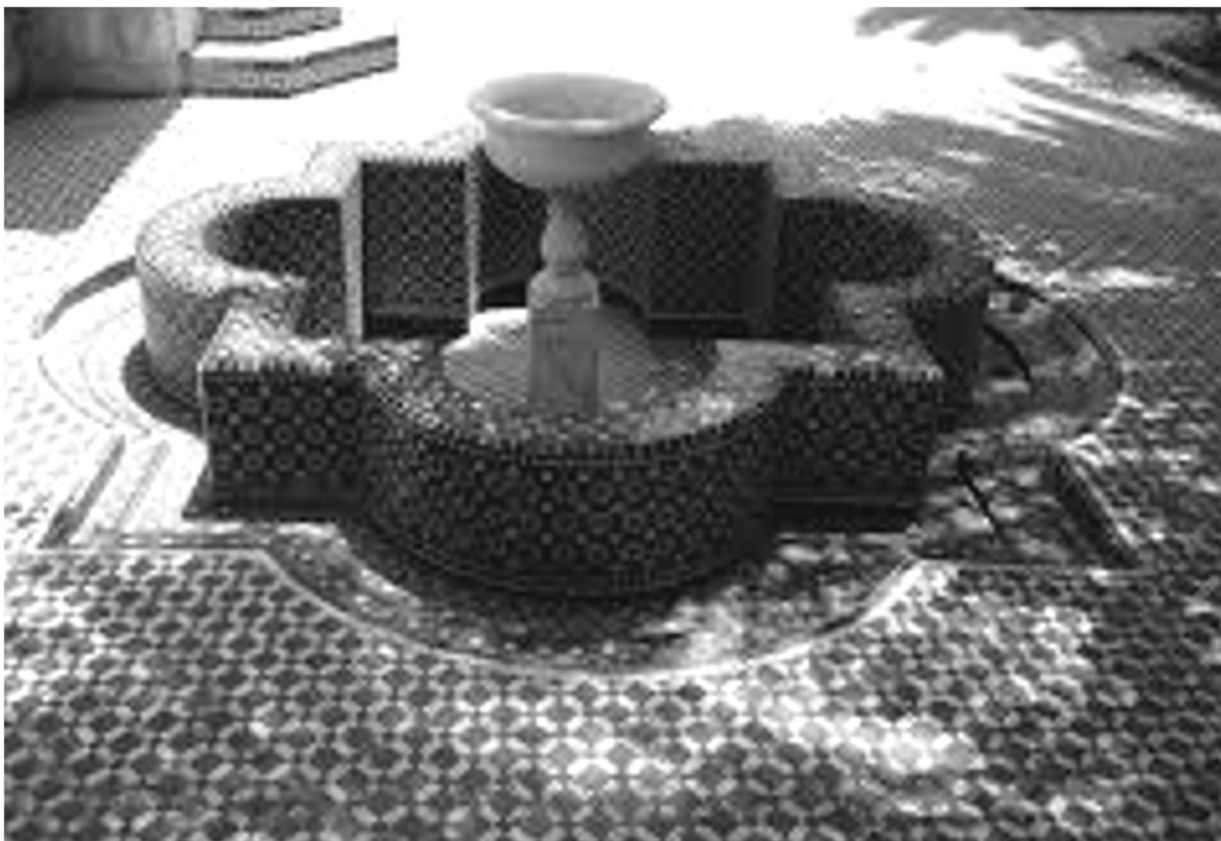


Photo: ALC-ALIF Photo Club